

India Can Win the Next Decade

India's progress is not a story anymore. It is on the path towards becoming a reality

INDIA WILL ONCE again serve as the bellwether for global growth in 2024. With the IMF projecting India's GDP growth to sustain at 6.3%, even as the world grapples with a slowdown at 2.9%, the country's business narrative is a contrast to the recession clouds hovering over Europe and other regions.

This optimism is palpable in the actions of both domestic and foreign investors. In 2023, India witnessed a record \$2 billion of monthly SIP inflows, coupled with foreign investors infusing \$20 billion into Indian equities and turning net buyers of Indian debt for the first time in four years. When I speak with investors abroad, it is evident that participating in India's growth story has transformed from a 'nice-to-have' to a 'must-have'.

SoftBank has been investing in Indian start-ups since 2013 and we have seen first-hand the country's transformation driven by infrastructure investments, India Stack, stable governance and a maturing tech ecosystem. Investors who put their faith in the India story have benefitted with handsome returns across multiple deals.

Looking forward to the next decade, there are ample reasons to be enthusiastic about India's potential as an economic and



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cultural superpower. While India is making rapid strides on all fronts, we are particularly excited about three themes that should have a multiplier effect on the Indian growth story.

Establishing more Tier I universities

Universities are the cornerstone of a vibrant economic ecosystem. US universities have played a key role in the development of Silicon Valley. Similarly, Europe is emerging as an AI hub despite economic and demographic headwinds because of the concentration of high-quality technical institutions. In India, institutions like the IITs have been instrumental in nurturing talent that has gone on to found and lead some of India's and the world's most influential companies.

To continue this legacy, it is imperative to scale these centres of excellence. India currently has 23 IITs and 31 NITs. It would be in India's interests to focus on increasing the number of high-quality universities that can offer best-in-class education and become centres of cutting-edge research. India is a unique example of a nation that has built a skills-based economy (IT, auto, pharma and now tech) akin to a developed country. As a result, it is critical that we can keep supplying skilled talent at scale to our economy. In this regard, it is exciting to see enlightened policy,